



The Voice That Carried

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The following is a tribute to the singer Peabo Bryson, who died on June 2, 2026, at the age of seventy-five, written to mark a career that carried a voice from a South Carolina farm to the title songs of two animated films.

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 He learned to sing on a farm outside Greenville, on his grandfather's land in Mauldin, South Carolina, before anyone had a reason to listen. By fourteen he was on the road with a local revue, a boy carrying grown men's songs from one town to the next. Peabo Bryson, who died on June 2 at seventy-five, spent the next sixty years doing only that, carrying a song to people who needed it carried. And the voice that did the carrying never seemed to strain.

2 The songs people knew best were not all his own to begin with. He sang the title song to one animated film, and then to another, and for a generation of children the sound of a fairy tale became, without their ever learning his name, the sound of Peabo Bryson. He sang 'Beauty and the Beast' with Celine Dion. He sang 'A Whole New World' with Regina Belle [Anaphora], and it rose to the top of the pop chart in the winter of 1993. Each recording won a Grammy. Grown listeners had found him long before, through 'If Ever You're in My Arms Again' and a row of records before it. But it was the cartoons that slipped his voice into childhoods that did not know they were keeping it [Metaphor].

3 What set him apart was not range alone but restraint. He could have oversung any of it, and the era rewarded singers who did. Instead he trusted the melody and stayed out of its way, and the feeling arrived because he had not forced it. Twenty-one albums came and went across five decades. And he kept the same unhurried tone through all of them, the sound of a man who had decided long ago that a song does not need to shout to be believed.

4 Two years ago his hometown painted him onto a wall. In the fall of 2024, Greenville unveiled a mural of him at a park near where he had started, and he came home to stand in front of it [Anecdote]. It was a small ceremony for a man who had filled large rooms [Antithesis]. But it was the right size, somehow, for what the work had always been: a voice from one ordinary place, carried out to everywhere, and then welcomed back.

5 His family said his voice had been the soundtrack to some of life's most cherished moments. That is the kind of thing families say, and in this case it happens to be true; the songs are already loved by people who will never trace them back to a farm in Mauldin. He leaves a wife, two children, and grandchildren who will grow up inside the recordings. The voice is not going anywhere. [Telegraphic sentence] It is in the films, and it will keep singing those fairy tales to children who are not yet born, which is a strange and ordinary kind of staying, the only kind a song was ever going to manage.

Devices, and why they are here:

Anaphora (paragraph 2): “He sang 'Beauty and the Beast' with Celine Dion. He sang 'A Whole New World' with Regina Belle”

Beginning two successive sentences with 'He sang' lines up the two Disney duets as matched halves of one achievement and gives the passage a measured, almost ceremonial beat. The repetition sits at the head of each sentence, which is what makes it anaphora rather than parallelism.

Metaphor (paragraph 2): “slipped his voice into childhoods that did not know they were keeping it”
Saying his voice was slipped into childhoods that did not know they were keeping it turns an abstract idea, lasting influence, into a quiet physical image, and carries the tribute's claim that his reach was largest where it was least noticed.

Anecdote (paragraph 4): “Greenville unveiled a mural of him at a park near where he had started, and he came home to stand in front of it”

The small, true story of the hometown mural grounds the praise in one concrete scene rather than in adjectives, letting a single homecoming stand for a whole career's relationship to the place that made him.

Antithesis (paragraph 4): “a small ceremony for a man who had filled large rooms”

Setting a small ceremony against the large rooms he had filled is the tribute's governing contrast, the small against the large, and it honors his reach precisely by understating the occasion.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 5): “The voice is not going anywhere.”

Five flat words assert the permanence the whole piece has been building toward, and their bluntness, set against the long final sentence that follows, makes the claim land as fact rather than as sentiment.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The writer's description of the mural unveiling as 'a small ceremony for a man who had filled large rooms' primarily serves to
 - A) honor the singer's reach by contrasting the modest occasion with the scale of his audience
 - B) suggest that his fame had faded by the end of his life
 - C) question whether the ceremony was worth his attention
 - D) fault his hometown for failing to hold a grander event
2. The relationship between the first paragraph and the second paragraph is best described as one in which the writer first
 - A) describes his final concert, then explains why he stopped performing
 - B) praises his character, then concedes his weaknesses
 - C) places the singer in his obscure beginnings, then traces how his voice reached a vast audience
 - D) states the cause of his death, then lists every award he received

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. The balanced contrast between the small ceremony and the large rooms praises Bryson's reach by understatement, which is why the keyed option fits; the next sentence confirms the modest scale was 'the right size.' The fault-the-hometown option misreads admiration as complaint, contradicting that confirmation. The faded-fame option inverts the passage, which presents the homecoming as fitting tribute, not decline. The not-worth-attention option imports a dismissiveness the warm, reverent passage never shows.

2. Answer C. The first paragraph sets Bryson on a Greenville farm and an unknown teenage revue, and the second carries his voice into the Disney songs a generation of children knew, so the keyed option tracks the movement from humble origin to mass reach. The cause-and-awards option misstates the text, which gives neither a cause of death nor a full award list. The concedes-weaknesses option describes a move this consecratory passage never makes; a tribute honors rather than rebuts. The final-concert option invents a retirement scene the passage does not contain.

Discussion questions:

1. Again and again the writer sets something small against something large: a farm boy and a generation's childhoods, a small ceremony and large rooms. How does that recurring contrast shape the way the piece honors Bryson?
2. The writer claims Bryson's gift was restraint, that 'a song does not need to shout to be believed.' Where does the writing itself practice that same restraint, and what does it gain by doing so?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The contrast lets the piece praise without inflating. Rather than calling Bryson great, the writer keeps pairing his ordinary origins with the enormous reach his voice finally had, so the reader measures the distance between the two and feels the size of the achievement directly. Honoring by contrast also fits the man the piece describes, someone who worked by understatement, so the form of the tribute matches its subject. The small-against-large pattern carries the central claim, that a voice from one modest place ended up everywhere, without ever having to announce it.
2. The writing withholds the big adjectives the occasion might invite. It does not call the voice legendary or the loss devastating; it states plain facts, a farm, a revue, two duets, a mural, and lets them accumulate. Even the family's grand line about a soundtrack to cherished moments is immediately cooled by the dry aside that this is 'the kind of thing families say.' By refusing to shout, the prose enacts the restraint it credits to Bryson, and the feeling lands harder because it was not forced, which is exactly the case the piece is making about his singing.

Writing prompt (Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to honor Peabo Bryson and to convey what made his voice and his manner distinctive. Consider how the writer's use of contrast, understatement, and concrete scenes from his life shapes the tribute.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- That Bryson wrote or starred in the Disney films. He sang the popular duet versions of their title songs, 'Beauty and the Beast' with Celine Dion and 'A Whole New World' with Regina Belle; the piece honors his voice, not authorship of the films or the songs.
- That the repeated 'He sang' opening two sentences is parallelism. Because the repetition falls at the start of successive sentences, it is anaphora; reserve parallelism for repeated structure that does not begin the clause.
- That a tribute must pile up superlatives to do its work. This one honors almost entirely by understatement and by setting small against large, so a reader scanning for big praise-words will miss where the actual honoring happens.

AP exam alignment:

This opener is built in the AP English Language source-passage mold. The Tribute register models Rhetorical Situation (Skill Category 1): a consecratory voice that recedes behind its subject, a community of listeners marking a death, and an epideictic purpose, to honor rather than to argue. The understatement, the small-against-large antithesis, and the short button set against the long final cadence give Style (Skill Category 7) concrete material, targeted by the first multiple-choice item, while the narrative-into-claim development from origin to reach gives Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5) a line to trace, targeted by the second. The two questions test different reading skills. The free-response prompt is a Q2 rhetorical analysis, the fitting choice because the passage consecrates a life rather than advancing a contestable claim; a Q3 argument is not stapled on, since the tribute offers no debatable position to defend, challenge, or qualify.